



DIAPHRAGMA

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PLAYERS RULEBOOK

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WHAT IS DIAPHRAGMA?



Welcome to **Diaphragma**, a modular narrative RPG built for fast, cinematic play, expressive storytelling and designed to be expanded through setting Frameworks. You'll read the room, find the angle, use your surroundings, exploit the weakness, and strike when everything lines up. When the dice hit the table, you've already done the work. Let's tell great stories!

The guard patrols the same arc. Every thirty seconds, the doorway is empty.

You've counted four passes. The lantern inside throws his shadow before he reaches the window — that's your warning. The mud will muffle your steps. The broken shutter gives you two handholds.

You don't move until the moment is right. When you do, it counts.

Each story runs on a **Framework**, a setting layer your Storyteller picks that gives you the world, the threats, and the tone. The rules handle the rest.

WHAT YOU NEED

DICE One d10.

SHEETS Character sheets PDF

WHY THIS BOOK EXISTS

I've been running games for a while. Long enough to have opinions.

D&D has something people underestimate: the round. Initiative sounds like a limitation. Players treat it like a cage. But that turn order is doing real work. Every player, no matter how quiet, no matter how much they're still figuring out what their character would do, gets a moment. The round finds them. That structure holds space for people.

But the system fights you. A player spots something. They describe an action that's creative and physical and alive. And I have to stop and figure out which stat applies, what the DC is, whether there's a proficiency here. By the time I've sorted it out, something's gone. The scene was happening. Now it isn't.

Narrative games solve that. **Powered by the Apocalypse, Blades in the Dark** — get out of the way of your players. One roll. Let the fiction breathe.

Until you notice who's doing most of the talking. The aggressive players. The ones who move first because the answer is always yes. The quiet player building toward something, waiting for the right moment — nobody's waiting for them. There is no turn. There's just whoever speaks next.

This game is an attempt to hold both things at once.

One die. One moment. The fiction drives everything. And a structure that makes space for every player at the table, not just the one who moves fastest.

CINEMATIC

One roll. One strong scene moment. No sluggish turns.

RESOURCEFUL

The room is your toolkit. The chandelier. The darkness. The guard's old wound.

EXPRESSIVE

No stat blocks. No class lists. Your character is their history.

MODULAR

The core is a skeleton. Frameworks are the flesh.

If you're a GM who wants to tinker, this is for you. If you're a player who wants to tell a great story without the rules getting in the way, this is for you. If you've ever had a quiet character who never got their moment, this is especially for you.

CORE CONCEPTS

SETTLE OR ROLL

Play it safe (**Settle**, raw result = 5) or risk it (**Roll**, 1d10). One die. No pools. You choose every time.

EDGES & BAINS

Favorable fiction adds **+1** per Edge. Unfavorable fiction subtracts. The scene around you matters as much as the die.

PARTIAL SUCCESS

A result of 7–9. You get what you wanted — but it costs you something. **The game lives here.**

NARRATIVE POINTS

A shared group currency earned from dramatic moments. Spend to reroll, inject a scene fact, or help an ally.

DESIGN GOALS

CINEMATIC One roll, one strong scene moment

RESOURCEFUL Gear, terrain, allies, information

SETUP-DRIVEN Create openings, don't grind

EXPRESSIVE Built from experience, not stat arrays

MODULAR Frameworks add the genre layer

NARRATIVE-FIRST Fiction first, rules second

FRAMEWORKS

The core rules are not the whole game.

Diaphragma is designed to be paired with a Framework — a campaign layer that adds what the core intentionally leaves open:

SETTING

ARCHETYPES

GEAR

ADVANCEMENT

TOPE

POWERS

ENEMIES

SPECIAL RULES

A horror Framework adds panic, injury, and fragile gear. A cyberpunk Framework adds hacking, cyberware, and corporate heat. A mythic fantasy Framework adds oaths, relics, and divine bargains. **The same core engine supports all of them.**

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

IF YOU'RE A PLAYER

Read **Chapters 1–3**. Start with Chapter 1 to understand how the game works, then Chapter 2 to build your character.

IF YOU'RE THE STORYTELLER

Read everything. Chapter 4 is yours. The Back Matter has all tables and reference sheets.

CORE RULES

How the game works. Start here.

CORE RESOLUTION

Diaphragma uses **one die**: a d10. When a character attempts something risky or uncertain, the player either **Settles** or **Rolls**.

SETTLE

Skip the roll. Your raw result is **5**. Safe and predictable — but you can never critically succeed or fail.

ROLL

Roll **1d10**. The number on the die is your raw result. Risk and reward both go up.

RESULT TIERS

After all Edges and Bains are applied:

RESULT	OUTCOME
Natural 1	Critical Failure
2 – 6	Failure
7 – 9	Partial Success
10+	Success
Natural 10	Crit Success*

Only if no Burden blocks success.

CRITICALS

Criticals only come from the **natural die result** — not from Edges pushing you to 10.

NATURAL 1

Always a **Critical Failure** — no Edges can prevent it.

NATURAL 10

Critical Success — but only if no relevant Burden blocks success.

SETTLING

If you Settle you can **never** critically fail or succeed.

RESOLUTION PROCEDURE

- 1 Describe what you want and **how** you do it.
- 2 The Storyteller decides if the action is possible in the fiction.
- 3 The Storyteller declares any relevant **Burden** before the roll or Settle.
- 4 The table identifies obvious **Edges** and possible **Bains**.
- 5 You choose to **Settle** or **Roll**.
- 6 Raw result: **5** if Settling, or the natural d10 result if Rolling.
- 7 Add all relevant **Edges** (+1 each).
- 8 Subtract all invoked **Bains**.
- 9 If a **Burden** applies, the best possible result is capped at **9**.
- 10 Read the final outcome tier.

PARTIAL SUCCESS

A Partial Success **always favors the player**. You get what you wanted – but the Storyteller adds a cost, complication, or new pressure. A Partial Success is **never** “nothing happens.”

Attack

You land the hit or reduce enemy Presence – but the enemy creates pressure back.

Investigate

You learn something useful – but you alert the enemy, lose time, or gain a Bain.

Escape

You get out – but you lose gear, get separated, or leave an ally exposed.

Convince

They believe you – but they want something in return, or word gets back to the wrong person.

PROFICIENCIES & SPECIALTIES

Characters are defined by what they have **learned, practiced, and lived through** — not by stat arrays.

PROFICIENCIES

Proficiencies are broad descriptions of what a character is good at, written as lived experience. A Proficiency does **not** grant a flat bonus. It is **fictional license** — the basis for arguing that an Edge is plausible at all.

I TRAINED AS A SOLDIER

I STUDIED MEDICINE IN WAR CAMPS

I HUNTED BEASTS IN THE MARSH FOR YEARS

I LEARNED TO READ PEOPLE AT COURT

A Proficiency does three things:

- Gates invocations** — establishes what actions and gear are within your competence.
- Justifies Edges** — lets you point to your background and say “this covers it.”
- Anchors Specialties** — it is the container your Specialties hang off of.

SPECIALTIES

Specialties are narrow, concrete focuses that hang off a Proficiency. When a Specialty clearly applies, it contributes **+1**.

PROFICIENCY	SPECIALTY
Trained as a soldier	Rifle marksmanship
Medicine in war camps	Battlefield surgery
Hunted beasts in the marsh	Tracking wetlands

Multiple Specialties can hang off the same Proficiency. This is the intended way to build a character — pick a few broad Proficiencies, then stack specific Specialties under them.

CHARACTER START

DEFAULT

Each character begins with about **3 Proficiencies** and **2 Specialties**, each hanging off one of their Proficiencies.

Both Specialties may go under the same Proficiency if you want to double down on a particular area.

BURDENS & BAINS

These are the two main ways the fiction pushes back against the characters.

BURDENS

Burdens are defining flaws. They are not temporary setbacks — they define who the character is.

I WILL NOT KNOWINGLY HARM A CHILD

I FREEZE WHEN FIRE CLOSES IN

I STILL TRUST HARLAN TOO MUCH

I CANNOT REFUSE A PUBLIC CHALLENGE

When a Burden applies it must be declared **before** the action is resolved. The action cannot achieve Success or Critical Success — the best possible outcome is **Partial Success**, even if Edges push the result to 10+.

GENERATING NP

If a Burden creates a dramatic moment that advances the story, it may generate **Narrative Points** for the group.

BAINS

Bains are active disadvantages that subtract from the final result. Usually temporary — bad positioning, enemy leverage, environmental hazards.

BROKEN LEG

-1

COVERED IN MUD

-1

BLINDED BY SPARKS

-2

MASTER SWORDSMAN'S GUARD

-2

PINNED BEHIND WEAK COVER

-1

Each Bain can normally be invoked **once**. Invoking a Bain costs the Storyteller **1ST**.

SEVERITY

VALUE

Normal

-1

Serious

-2

Extreme

-3

BURDENS VS BAINS – THE SAME THING, DIFFERENTLY

As a Burden: “Broken leg” is a defining lasting limitation. It follows the character everywhere, caps success on relevant actions, and cannot be easily removed.

As a Bain: “Broken leg” is a current condition worth -1 or -2. It can be healed, treated, or removed through play.

EDGES, GEAR & INVOKING

WHAT IS AN EDGE?

An **Edge** is any favorable fictional factor that helps the character. Each Edge is worth **+1** when invoked. Edges may come from gear, allies, position, environment, preparation, information, or enemy weakness.

LOADED REVOLVER +1

HIGH GROUND +1

SILVER CHAIN ALREADY IN HAND +1

ALLY IS PINNING THEM +1

I EXAMINED THE WOUND EARLIER +1

I KNOW THESE WOODS +1

INVOKING

Invoking means calling out an Edge and using it for +1. Invoking has **no currency cost** in the core rules. You may invoke Edges before or after the roll, when Settling or Rolling.

GEAR

Gear often creates Edges — but not all gear is equal.

USEFUL BY DEFAULT

A lantern in darkness. A rope on a cliff. An explosive against a barricade. Anyone can invoke these.

REQUIRES TRAINING

Guns, complex weapons, technical tools, ritual equipment. Usually needs a relevant Proficiency to invoke effectively.

EDGE ECONOMY

Keeping useful Edges in play is part of how characters stay alive. If a character loses their weapon, footing, allies, or prepared position, they may lose access to the Edges that let them safely reach Partial Success.

The Storyteller should treat the **creation and loss of Edges** as one of the main currencies of danger.

NARRATIVE POINTS & STORYTELLER TOKENS

NARRATIVE POINTS (NP)

NP are a shared player currency. Any NP generated goes into one common pool for the whole group.

NP may be generated when:

- A player rolls a **Critical Failure** and narrates it in a unique, story-advancing way
- A player rolls a **Critical Success** and narrates it in a unique, story-advancing way
- A **Burden** is invoked in a way that creates strong narrative momentum

Spending NP – each spend costs 1 NP:

SPEND	EFFECT
Reroll	Reroll a die you just rolled.
Injection	Add a useful fact or detail to the scene.
Flashback	Establish a brief prior preparation or memory.
Help	Give an ally a small immediate advantage.

STORYTELLER TOKENS (ST)

ST are the Storyteller's meta-currency. The Storyteller spends **1 ST** to invoke a Bain against a player's action.

Burdens **do not cost ST**. If a Burden is relevant, the Storyteller or player may bring it in freely.

ST ECONOMY

ST balance per encounter is still being tuned through playtesting. Ask your Storyteller how many ST they are working with per scene.

THE FLOW OF PLAY

NP flows from dramatic player moments. ST flows from Storyteller pressure. Both currencies reward engaging with the fiction rather than optimising around it.

When a player leans into a Burden or narrates a critical moment memorably, the group gains currency. When the Storyteller pushes back with Bains, they spend it.

CHAPTER 2

CHARACTERS

Building who you are.

CHARACTER CREATION

STATS AND CAPACITY

ANCHORS

GEAR

PROGRESSION

TRAITS

FLAWS

BURDENS

POWER LEVELS

GAMEPLAY LOOPS

Combat, scenes, and consequences.

PACING: SCENES VS DOWNTIME

CONFLICT: COMBAT

CONSEQUENCES

CONDITION TRACKS

CHAPTER 4

GM TOOLKIT

Running the game.

PRINCIPLES

NPCS AND THREATS

THE TOOLBOX

REFERENCE

Tables, definitions, and sheets.

QUICK REFERENCE TABLES

DEFINITIONS

CHARACTER SHEET